

Rafting Leadership Outline

Rensselaer Outing Club

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Leadership Requirements

- Candidates must identify the classification of leadership they are going for.
- Leadership candidate has completed the applicable sections of the Rafting Experience/Skill Based Leader Checklist.
- Candidates must demonstrate appropriate knowledge of the contents of this document.
 - Questioning during this process must be done with a current rafting leader present.
- 2/3rds of the club Executive Committee must vote to approve the candidate's leadership.

General

- Minimum of two boats are required on any club rafting trip, three is preferred
- At least %50 of the guides (2 minimum) on any trip need to have Swift Water Rescue Training.
- Trips are not to be taken on rivers in flood stage or rivers with rapids at or above a class V rating. (Ratings of rapids may vary with water levels)
- A leader must have run (and guided) a section of river before they take a trip down it.

- The trip leader has the responsibility to decide who can participate on trips, based on the participant's abilities and the skills required.
- Trip classification may change based on time of departure, change in water levels and changes in weather.

Classification of Trips

Beginner – Intermediate

- Up to Class III rapids
 - Examples: Sacandaga, Esopus, Deerfield Fife brook section, Hudson from Ripparius to the Glen, Hudson from Indian to North (low water levels)
- Reasonable weather and water temperatures
- Participant requirements:
 - Participants need no prior rafting experience
 - Participants will learn how to follow paddle commands and river safety techniques as specified in the river talk
 - Participants should demonstrate being comfortable in the water before going on a trip (Potentially at a pool session)

Intermediate – Advanced

- Up to Class IV rapids
 - Examples: Deerfield Dryway section, Dead River, Kennebec, Hudson from the Indian River to North Creek (High water levels), Beaver Taylorville section
- More extreme weather and water temperatures
 - Potential need for drysuits or other extreme weather gear
- Participant requirements:
 - Participants have been on a previous rafting trip and have demonstrated: competent paddling, ability to swim well, and extreme comfort in the water

Classification of Leaders

Assistant Leader

- This is an Assistant Leadership and trips can only be taken out with a full leader present. These leadership requirements are required in order to be the sole guide for a raft on a ROC rafting trip (guide a whole trip w/out supervision).
- The below requirements are required for Assistant Leadership and correlate with the Whitewater Rafting Leadership Approval Checklist and hence majority of them can be evaluated using said checklist.
- Experience/Skill Requirements:
 - Has been a participant on a ROC rafting trip
 - Ability to properly inflate rafts
 - Ability to identify, read and scout rapids
 - Ability to steer a raft and give guide commands in rapids
 - Ability to “rescue” (pull back in raft) a swimmer from the water and their paddle
 - Certified in CPR, WFA and Basic Whitewater Skills Training
 - Experience with throw ropes, rapid swimming and wading techniques.
- Knowledge Requirements:
 - Proper raft (participant) loading and its effects
 - River signals and positive pointing (are you ok, stop, go, whistles)
 - Hydrology and river features (Waves, eddies, holes, sieves, strainers, undercuts, pillows, upstream and downstream Vs)

Leader

- This is a full rafting leadership that only allows the taking out of single day trips of any difficulty.
- The below requirements are required for full Leadership and correlate with the Whitewater Rafting Leadership Approval Checklist and hence majority of them can be evaluated using said checklist.
- Requires all Assistant Leader requirements
- Additional Experience/Skill Requirements:

- Has been an Assistant Leader on a ROC Rafting trip
 - Ability to create and submit a trip sheet
 - Ability to give a proper pre trip safety talk
 - Ability to monitor time and water levels on the river
 - Ability to identify rapids and the rivers take out
 - Ability to patch a raft on the river
 - Ability to flip an overturned raft
 - Ability to properly research rivers pre trip
 - Ability to effectively communicate with trip participants and manage any concerns or inappropriate behavior that occurs. (Soft skills)
 - Certification in Swift Water Rescue
- Additional Knowledge Requirements:
 - Knowledge of where and how to portage (strainers and dangerous rapids)
 - Leave No Trace (LNT)
 - Adequate knowledge of group, participant and leader gear needed depending on weather and trip type (Outlined below)
 - Activities prohibited on ROC rafting trips (Outlined above)
 - Examples of beginner, intermediate and advance trips / rivers (Outlined above)
 - ROC trip size requirements and trip limitations (Outlined above)
 - Knowledge about cold water injuries and how to manage them
 - In depth knowledge of rescue techniques and procedures for complex/worst case river scenarios
 - Includes: Management of participants, upstream and downstream safety, foot entrapment scenarios, pinned boat scenarios, unconscious swimmer scenarios, mechanical advantage systems and tethered swimmer systems.

Overnight Leader

- This is a full rafting leadership that allows taking out of any type (multi-day) of permitted rafting trip
- Requires all Leader requirements.
- Additional Requirements:
 - The leader is already an approved ROC backpacking leader
 - Knows how to properly store overnight gear in rafts.

Recommended Equipment on Trips

General

Whole Trip Gear

- Boats
- Paddles (1 extra paddle, 1 guide paddle per boat)
- Throw Bags (At least 1 per boat, Minimum of 3 total)
- Boat Pumps
 - Car battery electric pump
 - Hand pumps (K-pump) (1 should be brought on the river)
- Straps (NRS) (multiple, more if more boats)
- Med Kit
- Dry bags and/or Cooler (for lunches, gear, clothes, etc.)
- Patch Kit (boat repair, duct tape)
- Rescue gear / Pin kit
 - Webbing
 - Prussiks (multiple)
 - Carabiners (multiple)
 - Pulleys

Participant Gear

- Proper clothing (weather dependent, booties, gloves, drysuit, wetsuit, etc.)
- Proper footwear
- Helmet
- Normal PFD (non-rescue)
- Water (with carabiner)
- Lunch/snacks
- Dry clothes and a towel for takeout
- Sunscreen

Additional Guide/Leader Gear

- Rescue PFD
 - Rescue/river knife
 - Whistle
 - Prussiks
 - Webbing
 - Carabiners
- Flip line
- Extra snacks (in addition to their own)
- Extra water (in addition to their own)

- Sunscreen (extra on boat)
- Extra layers
- Phone (At least one leader should have their phone on the river)

Multi-Day Trips

- Guide book, hiking boots, extra rope, compass (knowledge to use), tents, sleeping bags, sleeping pads, packs, additional food and water, stove, cooking/eating utensils, headlamps, spare batteries, spare matches or lighters, extra dry clothing.

Recommended Pre-Trip Safety Talk Topics

Gear

- PFD
 - Keep tight and on at all times
- Helmet
 - Keep tight and on at all times
- Paddle
 - How to hold
 - Don't let go of T grip

Safety

- If you fall in
 - White water swim position
 - Never try and stand up on the river
 - Be a part of your own rescue
 - Swim where your guide is pointing
 - Positive pointing
- Go over throw ropes and demonstrate their proper use
- Go over and demonstrate how to pull someone back into the boat
- Whistles

Paddling

- How to sit in the boat
- How to brace
- How to paddle
- Typical paddle commands

Always listen to your guide and never try to stand up in the river!